

The Pull-Away Antidote

What to do when they go cold, go quiet, or disappear, without losing yourself in the process.

4

PARTS TO READ

13

SCRIPTS THAT WORK

1

LOOP TO BREAK

You are not crazy. You are not too much. You did not do anything wrong. Your body is doing exactly what it was built to do, and this guide will show you how to respond from a place of security instead of panic.

1 Why Your Body Goes Into Panic Mode

2 The Do Not React List

3 The Somatic Reset

4 Text Scripts A-I

5 In-Person Scripts J-M

6 The Standard Setter

7 The Science Behind the Script

★ Read Part 4 with your phone open

1 THE INTRODUCTION

Your Nervous System Is Not Broken

Why you panic when they pull away, and why it is not a character flaw

BEFORE YOU READ ANYTHING ELSE

Take a deep breath. Drop your shoulders. Unclench your jaw. You are exhausted. And you do not even know what you did wrong. Whatever happened, the silence, the one-word reply, the "I need space" out of nowhere, none of it means you are too much. It means your nervous systems are doing what nervous systems do.

HERE IS THE SCIENCE

Your brain is wired to treat losing someone close to you the same way it treats physical danger. When they pull away, the alarm center in your brain (the amygdala) fires off like a smoke alarm. Your body floods with cortisol and adrenaline. Your heart races, your stomach knots up, and you feel an overwhelming urge to fix it right now. Brain scans show that being rejected activates the same regions as physical pain. The panic is real. You are not being dramatic.

Eisenberger et al. (2003) · UCLA · Levine & Heller (2010), Attached

"Maybe they went cold overnight. Maybe they answered your real message with "yeah lol." Maybe they asked for space after what felt like a great week. Maybe it has been three days of silence and you have checked your phone so many times you lost count. You are not crazy. You are not too much. You did not do anything wrong."

Rejection activates the same brain regions as pain

~25%

of adults have an anxious attachment style

~25%

have an avoidant attachment style

WHY THE LOOP KEEPS REPEATING



Things Feel Good
Close, connected, hopeful



They Get Scared
Closeness triggers their alarm



They Pull Away
Cold, quiet, distant



You Panic and Reach
Texts, calls, spiraling



They Pull Away More
Your reach triggers their retreat

REAL LIFE EXAMPLE

"You had a perfect Sunday together. They were texting you all day Monday. Then Tuesday went quiet. By Wednesday you had sent four texts and were refreshing their Instagram wondering if they were okay or if you had done something. You had not done anything. Their nervous system just hit the panic button."

This is the anxious-avoidant cycle. The more you reach, the more they pull. The more they pull, the more you panic and reach. Starting today, you are breaking that loop.

WHAT IS HAPPENING IN YOU

- Brain reads their withdrawal as a survival threat
- Amygdala fires, flooding you with stress chemicals
- Logical thinking goes offline and panic takes over
- Urge to reach out feels urgent and rational

WHAT IS HAPPENING IN THEM

- Closeness triggers their own alarm system
- Pulling away is self-protection, not rejection
- Your reaching makes them feel more overwhelmed
- They are not doing this on purpose either



WHY YOU CANNOT STOP THINKING ABOUT THEM

The hot-and-cold pattern your person has created is actually addictive, and not in a small way. It works exactly the way slot machines do. Behaviorist B.F. Skinner found that when rewards are unpredictable, your brain chases them harder, not less. The on-and-off behavior is not just confusing. It is literally training your brain to be hooked.

Skinner (1957) · Variable Ratio Reinforcement · Fisher et al. (2005) · Romantic Love and Dopamine

The Do Not React List

These feel like closeness to you. They feel like pressure to them. Every single time.



WHAT PROTEST BEHAVIORS ACTUALLY ARE

Bowlby called them protest behaviors: automatic actions your attachment system takes when it senses your person slipping away. They are not character flaws. They are ancient survival wiring. A baby cries and the caregiver comes back. That system is still running in you. The problem is that protest behaviors work on anxious and secure partners, but they backfire completely on avoidants — because avoidants read emotional intensity as a threat and move further away, not closer.

THE 6 FORMS PROTEST TAKES — INCLUDING THE ONES YOU DON'T RECOGNIZE

1

Pursuit Escalation

The double text. The "are we okay?" follow-up. The long message explaining how their silence makes you feel. Each one is your nervous system trying to reestablish contact. They feel necessary. To an avoidant, they register as pressure, and pressure is exactly what triggers more distance.

The rule: One message. Then you wait. The urgency you feel is a chemical state, not a deadline.

2

The Anger Protest

Picking a fight about the dishes when the real issue is that they went cold again. Sending a sharp, cutting text to finally get some kind of reaction. The anger is real, but the target is usually a stand-in for "I need you to acknowledge I exist." Any response — even a bad one — feels better than silence. Avoidants do not experience it that way. They experience it as confirmation that closeness is dangerous.

The rule: Name what is actually happening. "I felt disconnected and it scared me" lands differently than a fight about plans.

3

The Jealousy Bid

Posting something to look desirable. Mentioning that someone showed interest in you. Flirting in their line of sight. The logic is unconscious: if I seem wanted, they will want me. And jealousy bids do sometimes work in the short term. But they teach the avoidant that your connection is a competition, not a safe place — which makes them more defended, not less.

The rule: Jealousy bids communicate insecurity even when they seem to "work." They are borrowing against trust.

4

Counter-Withdrawal — Going Cold Yourself

This one is easy to miss because it looks nothing like anxiety. You go silent. You give them the cold shoulder. You disappear for a few days to see if they reach out. It feels like taking back control. But it is still protest — you are trying to trigger their fear of losing you. The problem is that avoidants do not chase the way you do. They often feel relief when the pressure lifts, which makes the silence even more painful for you.

The rule: Going cold to get a reaction is still the attachment system in protest mode. It rarely produces what you actually want.

5

The Ultimatum That Is Not Real

"Maybe we should just break up." Said not because you mean it, but because you need them to say they do not want that. This is protest in its most desperate form. The goal is reassurance. But to an avoidant, a threat to leave — even an unmeant one — is a reason to start preparing for exactly that. You may get a short burst of closeness followed by more distance as they pull back to protect themselves.

6

Erasing Yourself to Not Trigger Them

This is the quietest protest behavior and the most overlooked. You stop having needs. You agree to things that do not work for you. You make yourself smaller and easier to be around, hoping that if you stop triggering the pull-away, they will finally stay. But this is still protest — you are reorganizing your entire self around their avoidance. And it does not create security. It creates resentment, confusion, and a version of you that is increasingly invisible.

The rule: Shrinking yourself is not the same as being secure. You cannot earn consistent love by making yourself easier to leave.

PROTEST IN ACTION (ALL FORMS)

- "Hey" → "You there?" → "Are we okay?" → "Fine."
- Starting a fight about something unrelated
- Posting a photo to look wanted
- Going cold and waiting to see if they notice

REGULATED RESPONSE (DO THIS)

- One message. Phone down. Regulate first.
- Name the real thing: "I felt disconnected."
- Stay visible as yourself, not as a reaction to them
- Say what you need once, clearly, from a calm body

“

Every protest behavior makes sense. Your nervous system is doing exactly what it was built to do. The goal is not to stop feeling it. The goal is to stop acting from it.

The Somatic Reset

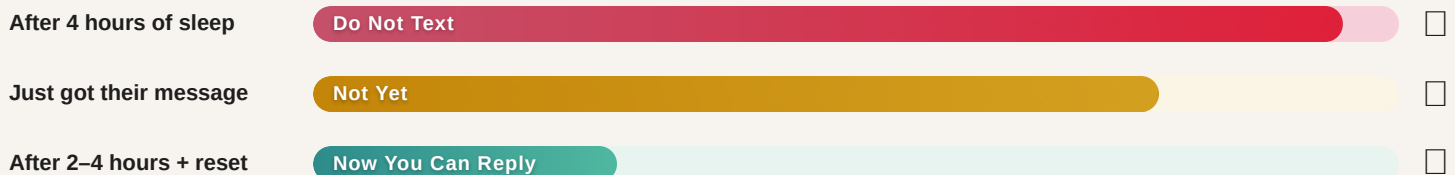
You cannot send a calm text from a panicking body. Fix your body first.

THE CORE RULE

Get out of panic mode before you touch your keyboard.

Right now, your body is flooded with stress chemicals that literally shut down the thinking part of your brain. That means every decision you make right now will come from panic, not wisdom. The urgency you feel is a chemical spike, not intuition. Wait for it to pass.

YOUR PANIC LEVEL RIGHT NOW



THE 2-TO-4-HOUR RULE

If they send a triggering message ("I need space," "I've just been busy," or even silence), you are not allowed to reply for at least 2 to 4 hours. If it is late at night, sleep on it. The intense urgency you feel is a stress chemical spike. It will physically pass. Give your body time to settle before you touch your keyboard.

HOW TO FLIP YOUR BODY'S CALM SWITCH

1 The Double Inhale: Fastest Anxiety Fix Proven by Science

Two quick sniffs in through your nose, then one long slow exhale through your mouth. Repeat three times. The long exhale is what activates your body's built-in calm switch, the vagus nerve.

Why this works: Stanford researchers (Balban et al., 2023) found this is the fastest breathing technique to lower heart rate and reduce anxiety. Faster than a single deep breath. Do this before replying to any message that makes your chest tight.

2 Cold Water on Your Face

Splashing cold water on your cheeks triggers the diving reflex, a hard-wired physiological response that slows your heart rate almost immediately. It works in under a minute and requires nothing except a sink.

Why this works: Your body physically cannot stay in full panic mode when the diving reflex activates. It is a biological override, not a mindset shift.

3 Pull Your Energy Back to Yourself

Right now, every bit of your mental energy is pointed at them. Go to the gym. Call a friend and actually enjoy the conversation. Work on something you care about. The goal is to make your life loud enough that their silence is just one thing happening, not everything.

Why this works: When your well-being does not depend entirely on their behavior, the silence hurts less. You stop reacting from panic and start responding from choice.

"They texted at 9pm: 'I think I need a little space.' Your stomach dropped. You typed six different responses and deleted them all. Instead of sending anything, you put your phone face down, did the double inhale three times, texted your friend to come over, and replied at 11am the next morning. That one choice completely changed the dynamic."

The version of you who replies from a settled body always sends a better message than the version who replies from panic. Always.

WHY YOUR CALM CHANGES EVERYTHING



Human nervous systems co-regulate, meaning your physiological calm can literally help regulate another person's stress response. When you stay grounded during a pull-away, it is not just emotionally helpful. It is biologically helpful. Your steady energy, calm tone, and slow reply speed physically lower their stress hormones. You become the safe signal their nervous system has been looking for.

Porges (2011) · Polyvagal Theory · Coan et al. (2006) · Partner Regulation fMRI Study · Balban et al. (2023) · Stanford

Text Scripts A – F

Exactly what to say in the most common pull-away situations. Warm and boundaried at the same time.



THE ENERGY BEHIND EVERY SCRIPT

Secure people do not play games. But they also do not stay silent when something is not working. They say what they need clearly, without anger, and without begging. That is the energy in every script below. Not cold. Not desperate. Secure.

SCENARIO A: THEY SAY "I NEED SPACE"

THE SECURE SCRIPT

"Got it. Take the time you need. I'll be here when you're ready."

Why this works: You gave them exactly what they asked for, and YOU framed it as your choice, not you sitting around waiting. That one small shift changes the whole dynamic.

HOW THIS PLAYS OUT

hey i've just been feeling really overwhelmed and i think i need some space

Got it. Take the time you need. I'll be here when you're ready.

You said it once. Then you put the phone down.

One message. No follow-up. That is the move.

SCENARIO B: THEY REPLY WITH A ONE-WORD ANSWER

BEST OPTION

[No reply. Send nothing.]

Silence is a complete answer. You matched their energy without chasing. Your life is moving. You are not sitting by your phone waiting.

IF YOU MUST REPLY

"Haha okay. Hope your day's good!"

Short, warm, and done. You are not dependent on their response to feel okay.

HOW THIS PLAYS OUT

yeah lol

Haha okay. Hope your day's good!

No next message. No "?". Done.

SCENARIO C: AFTER DAYS OF SILENCE, THEY TEXT "HEY"

THE SECURE SCRIPT

"Hey! Been a pretty full week over here. How are you?"

Warm, but not dropping everything. You are not punishing them. You are also not acting like nothing happened. You are just... fine. Living your life. That is the most attractive version of yourself.

□ HOW THIS PLAYS OUT

Hey

Hey! Been a pretty full week over here. How are you?

Warm. Not desperate. Not cold.

Text Scripts D – I & In-Person J – M

Breadcrumbs, the slow fade, and everything that happens face to face

SCENARIO D: THEY TEXT "I MISS YOU" AFTER GOING COLD

THE SECURE SCRIPT

"Miss you too. Want to actually catch up? I'm free later this week."

"I miss you" with no follow-through is a breadcrumb. This acknowledges the feeling without rewarding the disappearing act. You are nudging toward a real connection instead of letting them collect your warmth and go cold again.

□ HOW THIS PLAYS OUT

i miss you

Miss you too. Want to actually catch up? I'm free later this week.

Warm, but with an ask attached. That is the difference.

SCENARIO E: THEY CANCEL LAST MINUTE WITH A VAGUE EXCUSE

THE SECURE SCRIPT

"No worries! Gonna keep my plans. Let me know when you can actually commit to a time."

You are not punishing them. But you are not pretending last-minute canceling is fine. "When you can actually commit" names the pattern without a lecture. That is the secure move.

□ HOW THIS PLAYS OUT

hey something came up, can we raincheck?

No worries! Gonna keep my plans. Let me know when you can actually commit to a time.

Friendly tone. Clear message. Not waiting around.

SCENARIO F: THEY SAY "I DON'T KNOW WHAT I WANT RIGHT NOW"

THE SECURE SCRIPT

"Thanks for being honest. I need to be with someone who actually knows they want to be here. Take the time to figure it out. I'll keep moving in the meantime."

"I don't know what I want is not a commitment. This is not an ultimatum. It is the truth. You need clarity to feel safe, and you are not putting your life on pause while they figure it out."

SCENARIO G: WATCHING YOUR STORIES BUT NOT TEXTING

THE SECURE SCRIPT

[No reply. Send nothing.]

Watching without reaching out is how an avoidant stays connected without being vulnerable. If you text first, you take all the pressure off them. Hold your ground. They know how to reach out.

SCENARIO H: THEY WERE GOOD, THEN WENT COLD AGAIN

THE SECURE SCRIPT

"Hey, things have felt a bit off lately and I just wanted to name it. Not trying to start anything. Just noticed. I'm here."

You name the shift calmly, no accusation, no panic. You are not chasing. You are not pretending nothing happened. You leave the door open and step back.

IN-PERSON SCRIPTS: WHEN THE PULL-AWAY HAPPENS FACE TO FACE

J: THEY ACT LIKE NOTHING HAPPENED

Say this:

"Hey, it's good to see you. I did notice things felt a little off lately. Just wanted to say that out loud."

Say it once. Calm tone. No edge. Then let it breathe.

K: THEY GO DISTANT MID-DATE

Say this:

"You seem a little far away right now. Everything okay?"

Gentle curiosity, not accusation. Check in once. If they say "I'm fine," trust it.

L: "I DON'T KNOW IF I'M READY FOR SOMETHING SERIOUS"

Say this:

"I appreciate you telling me. I'm not going to push. But I'm looking for something real. So if that's not where you are, I get it. I just need to know."

No tears, no convincing. Steady eye contact. You mean it.

M: THEY SHUT DOWN DURING A CONFLICT

Say this:

"I can see this is hard. I'm not going anywhere. Take a few minutes if you need it. I do want us to come back to this."

Stay regulated. Give them space without abandoning the conversation.

NOT THIS



Following them around the room. Sending a wall of texts after they leave. Raising your voice. "Are you mad at me? Did I do something? Why are you being like this?" That chasing energy hands them all the power and makes the shutdown worse.

The Standard Setter

Them coming back is a starting point, not a finish line



HERE IS WHAT EVERYONE SKIPS

Using these scripts and keeping your cool will often make them come back. The calm, unbothered, not-chasing energy actually lowers an avoidant's defenses. It works. But them coming back is not the goal. It is information. What they do when they re-enter tells you almost everything.

WHAT TO PAY ATTENTION TO WHEN THEY COME BACK

□ SIGNS OF REAL CHANGE

- ✓ They acknowledge what happened instead of acting like nothing did
- ✓ They come back with words AND follow-through
- ✓ The cycles are getting shorter over time
- ✓ They bring up the pattern themselves without you having to
- ✓ Their actions over 2–4 weeks match their words when they returned

△ BREADCRUMBS TO WATCH FOR

- ✗ Acts warm and close but never names what happened
- ✗ Says all the right things but behavior doesn't change
- ✗ The cycle repeats with no growth between rounds
- ✗ Gets defensive or vague when you try to name the pattern
- ✗ Warm moments are intense but brief, then cold again

THE STANDARD SETTER CONVERSATION

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION IN PERSON OR ON A CALL. NOT OVER TEXT.

"I genuinely like spending time with you, and I want to see where this goes. But I need consistency to feel safe. The hot and cold is hard on me. I'm not asking for perfection, just honesty and follow-through. Is that something you can do right now?"

Why this works: You are naming a need without attacking them. You are asking about their capacity with real curiosity, not a threat. And you are giving them a chance to be honest. If they say yes, watch their actions. If they say no, or if they repeat the pattern, you have your answer.

WHEN THEY COME BACK: THE DECISION MAP

STARTING POINT

They Reach Out and Come Back

RESPOND WITH THE SECURE SCRIPT

Then watch what they consistently DO over 2–4 weeks

SHOWS UP CONSISTENTLY

Have the Standard Setter talk (see the script above)

Keep watching their actions. Words are nice. Behavior is the truth.

GOES HOT & COLD AGAIN

That is your answer. Not a maybe. Choose yourself.

You deserve someone who shows up. You are not asking too much.

“

A person with secure attachment does not stay in something that keeps their nervous system in permanent emergency mode. You were not built for a constant loop of chase and pull-away. You deserve something consistent.

I can love someone and still decide this is not working for me.

My nervous system deserves peace. Not constant activation.

Watching their actions is not punishment. It is self-respect.

Choosing myself is not giving up. It is the most secure thing I can do.

The Science Behind the Script

Because "too needy" was never a diagnosis. It was a misread of your nervous system.



WHY THIS SECTION EXISTS

Every concept in this guide comes from real research. If you have ever been told you are "too much": here is what the science actually says about what is happening inside you. Read this on the nights when your brain tells you your reaction is irrational. It is not.



1. ATTACHMENT THEORY · WHY WE LOVE THE WAY WE LOVE

The core ideas in this guide, including the anxious-avoidant cycle, the urge to chase, and the shutdown response, come from the landmark book *Attached* by Dr. Amir Levine and Rachel Heller. Their work built on decades of research by Bowlby and Ainsworth. Research estimates roughly 25% of adults have an anxious attachment style and around 25% have an avoidant style, though figures vary across studies. These two types are drawn to each other more than any other pairing. The cycle you are in is well-documented and very common.

Levine & Heller (2010), Attached · Bowlby (1969, 1973) · Ainsworth (1978)



2. POLYVAGAL THEORY · YOUR BODY'S CALM SWITCH

The breathing and body techniques in Part Three come from Polyvagal Theory, developed by Dr. Stephen Porges. Your vagus nerve plays a key role in regulating your stress response. When you extend your exhale (breathing out longer than you breathe in), it helps shift your body out of panic mode and into a calmer state. A 2023 Stanford study found that the double-inhale breath pattern is one of the most effective real-time stress reducers ever tested.

Porges (2011) · Polyvagal Theory · Balban et al. (2023) · Stanford University



3. BRAIN SCANS · REJECTION HURTS LIKE PHYSICAL PAIN

Dr. Naomi Eisenberger at UCLA used brain imaging to show that social rejection activates the same exact areas of the brain as physical pain. When your person goes cold, your brain's alarm center reads it as a threat to your survival and floods your body with stress chemicals. The chest tightness, the stomach knot, the racing heart: all of it is your body responding to a real threat signal. You are not being dramatic.

Eisenberger et al. (2003) · UCLA · Kross et al. (2011) · PNAS



4. INTERMITTENT REINFORCEMENT · WHY YOU CANNOT STOP THINKING ABOUT THEM

Behaviorist B.F. Skinner found that when rewards are unpredictable, the drive to chase them gets stronger, not weaker. This is called Variable Ratio Reinforcement, the same mechanism that makes gambling addictive. The hot-and-cold pattern is not just confusing. It is neurologically addictive. Understanding this is how you start to break it.

Skinner (1957) · Reinforcement Schedules · Fisher et al. (2005) · Romantic Love Neuroimaging



5. EARNED SECURE ATTACHMENT · YOU CAN CHANGE

Attachment styles are formed in childhood, but they are not permanent. Research shows that adults can build what scientists call Earned Secure Attachment, meaning you can move toward security through self-awareness, therapy, and healthier relationships, regardless of where you started. What matters is not what happened to you in childhood but how clearly you can understand and talk about it. The work you are doing right now counts.

Main (1990) · Adult Attachment Interview · Siegel (1999) · The Developing Mind

[📖 Attached by Amir Levine & Rachel Heller \(start here\)](#)[📖 The Polyvagal Theory by Stephen Porges](#)[📖 Hold Me Tight by Dr. Sue Johnson](#)[📖 Wired for Love by Stan Tatkin](#)

“

You came into this guide with a knot in your stomach. You now know why your body reacts the way it does. You know how to stop the behaviors that make things worse. You know how to calm yourself down. And you know what to say in every scenario. More than any of that: you are not too much. You are not broken. You are someone whose nervous system responds to connection the way it was built to, and who now has the tools to respond from security instead of panic.

You deserve someone who is consistent.

Someone who shows up. Someone who does not make you wonder.

With love and attachment science, Ash · Couples Educator

[Anxious Attachment](#)[Avoidant Patterns](#)[Somatic Tools](#)[Secure Attachment](#)[Relationship Scripts](#)